ZOLPIDEM

Complex sleep behaviours

Short-term only

CHEMICAL NAME N,N-dimethyl-2-[6-methyl-2-(4-methylphenyl)imidazo[1,2-a]pyridin-3-yl]acetamide (tartrate)

CLASS Non-benzodiazepine hypnotic ("Z-drug", imidazopyridine)

TRADE NAMES Stilnox · Ambien · Zolpidem (generic) · Intermezzo (SL)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Short-term treatment of insomnia (2–4 weeks) when severe, disabling or distressing.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** immediately before bed (only if ≥7–8 h available for sleep).
- Taken on an empty stomach for faster onset.
- Lowest dose for the shortest time.

DOSAGES

- **Adult:** 5–10 mg at bedtime (women: 5 mg in many countries due to slower clearance); max 10 mg.
- **Elderly/hepatic impairment:** 5 mg.
- Max duration 4 weeks including taper.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 15–30 min. **Duration:** 6–8 h.
- Metabolised by CYP3A4 (inactive metabolites).
- Excreted in urine and faeces. **t½:** 2–3 h (longer in elderly, women, liver disease).

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Give at bedtime only when patient ready to sleep.
- Falls precautions; bed alarm in elderly.
- Ask about night-time behaviours.
- Sleep hygiene advice; limit duration.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Selective agonist at **GABA-A receptors containing α1 subunit** (benzodiazepine site) → hypnotic with weak anxiolytic/anticonvulsant effects.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Next-day drowsiness, dizziness.
- Headache, nausea.
- Amnesia.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Complex sleep behaviours: sleep-walking, sleep-driving, eating, with amnesia → serious injury/death.
- Dependence, rebound insomnia, withdrawal.
- Falls/fractures in elderly; respiratory depression with opioids.
- Hallucinations, confusion.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Previous complex sleep behaviour with Z-drugs.
- Severe respiratory insufficiency, sleep apnoea; myasthenia gravis.
- Severe hepatic impairment.
- Children.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, opioids, sedatives:** ↑ CNS and respiratory depression.
- **CYP3A4 inhibitors (ketoconazole):** ↑ levels.
- **Rifampicin:** ↓ effect.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take only when going straight to bed with 7–8 hours available.
- Do not drive the next morning if drowsy; avoid alcohol.
- Stop and report any sleep-walking or night-time activities you cannot remember.
- Short-term use only.

KEY POINTS

- Z-drug hypnotic (α1 GABA-A).
- Complex sleep behaviours.
- 5–10 mg at bedtime (5 mg elderly/women).
- Max 4 weeks; falls risk.